

Being worried about water and therefore not using AI

Posted by u/sammoga123 • 0 points • 12 comments

This happened quite a while ago, although I don't think I uploaded it haha.

Since that is a subreddit about AI, it's obvious that more than one person will try to mention how worrying about water due to AI issues is quite silly. I thought it was something else because of the meme image, but in the end I was disappointed to see that it wasn't.

Comments

u/No-Age-1044 • 1 points • 2026-02-22 09:18 UTC

Data centers don't destroy water, just use them to cool... like any factory, much less than most factories to be true, but nowadays it is the only argument that the antis think its true have so they repeat it once and again even if they sound ignorants.

u/see-more_options • 1 points • 2026-02-22 07:18 UTC

It's fascinating how little they know about stuff they shit on so confidently.

u/SnooOpinions6451 • 2 points • 2026-02-22 01:51 UTC

This is because most people do not know how technology even functions. Nexflix, at its minimum multiplier, consumes 4x as much water (560 million gallons) than ai at its highest (2 billion prompts per day)

Its just that ai is the thing thats morally ok to attack rather than attacking netflix or any bigger data center because these people use those services consistently.

u/magicalmanenergy33 • 11 points • 2026-02-22 01:00 UTC

People seem to believe that all ai there is some oogabooga mega mean DATA Center somewhere literally eating water and destroying the world. People don't seem to realize that all data centers aren't the same. They are owned by different companies and are in different places in the entire world.

Some Data centers = built following all rules an laws and permits and were built somewhere that there is plenty of water.

Some data centers = built breaking laws and rules cuz they have bajillions of dollars and built it somewhere that it IS effecting the people/city directly

Some data centers = are in a completely different country.

And then there's local ai you can run on your own computer without internet, trained on your own stuff.

People seem to think that suddenly it's AI's fault for everything, but forget it didn't exist 4 years ago and we already have other industries that are far far more destructive and entrenched in our society.

But ai is the easy low hanging fruit, easy scape goat, so people can lie to themselves and think they are taking some great "moral stance" just saying "ai bad!" But it's a much more complicated situation. Even if ai suddenly disappears over night (which it can't) that somehow that would fix everything. News flash. Things are already F'd up before ai came into the picture.

u/sammoga123 • 5 points • 2026-02-22 01:21 UTC

We would have died long ago, to be honest. The internet has existed for about 25 years and consumption keeps increasing.

But, well, I've even come across people who think a credit or debit card is "free money" XD. In fact, I remember a case of a girl who used Apple Pay to pay for a lot of things, and in the end, it cost her a fortune. Then she wanted to talk to Apple support and asked to speak to Steve Jobs; she didn't even know he'd been dead for a decade! XD.

And I've also seen people here who believe that local models are a lie and don't really exist. There are different kinds of people who believe different kinds of things, with no logical connection between them, all because they know absolutely nothing and speak because they can use the internet. That makes me think that the use of a certain technological product shouldn't be allowed if you don't even know what it is.

u/Ok_Top9254 • 2 points • 2026-02-21 22:31 UTC

C.ai is mostly used by teenagers, it doesn't really make sense to lead a meaningful conversation there, but it's nice that there are still smart people.

But anyway wall of text incoming:

Most of the papers regarding datacenter water use are not directly from cooling but electricity use, aka thermoelectric plants. These are responsible for over 30% of the water usage of the US. The actual on-site usage for cooling is tiny, around 0.02% of national usage, and that's for all datacenters, not AI specific ones, and especially not taking into account that most datacenters have variety of usage, out of which AI workloads are only about 10-20% these days. And EVEN THEN, AI workloads are not "embarrassingly parallel" (yes this is a scientific name) for large systems. Utilization is mostly around 50-70%, so out of all that AI is only around 0.003% or so. So this is mainly on the power plants using water, not datacenters.

Aside from power plants using a ton of water, around 40% is used for irrigation in agriculture. Unlike from power plant evaporation, irrigation adds pesticides into water that make it unusable. So farms actually *consume* water, unlike datacenters. This is why cattle uses so much water. You need to grow the animals for dozen months, give them water to drink and also feed them crops like corn that themselves need water to grow. It makes 10x more sense to protest against meat than datacenters this way.

And speaking of corn there is another thing. TechnologyConnections had great videos on youtube about it. About 35% of all corn fields are used to make ethanol, that's then used for gas to reduce fuel

emissions. If we instead all converted these to solar farms, they would cover over twice the yearly electricity demand of the whole US.

Despite these fields being mostly rain irrigated, even from just the few dry days a year, due to the sheer area they occupy, they have 1-2% of the national water usage. But obviously, that is nothing compared to replacing all the gas and coal power plants that use 30% of total water. And especially actually hurting the environment, air quality and even killing people due to miners inhaling radioactive dust from coal, unlike AI. Quite literally not seeing the forest for the trees.

u/Luciferspants • 4 points • 2026-02-21 21:52 UTC

It is so fucking easy to research this.

"AI is using up all the water" Is such a tiring argument, especially in 2026.

There are dudes out there that probably say this whilst leaving the sink on for far too long. How many people have said this yet let the water run whilst brushing their teeth? How many people shower for 30 minutes, when they only need to shower for 5-10 minutes?

I could go on and on, but wasting water is a lot more common than these people think. Depending on how often you use the bathroom, you could've used at least 5 gallons of water per day flushing the toilet alone.

Boy... I wonder how they'd react when they find out how many gallons of water is used at a car wash for just SINGLE car wash? Oh wait, we have an approximate answer of course. It's around 35-50 gallons of waters used at a professional car wash for a single car. Depending on how many cars visit the car wash, that could be thousands of gallons of water used per day.

u/calicocatfuture • 8 points • 2026-02-21 20:51 UTC

it's understandable that there are some things that hurt the environment that are inevitable to use. however eating meat is not technically "essential" since vegans/vegetarians exist, and as stated it uses much more water so why would they not start there or do both? also, the yellow pfp sabotaged themselves hard once they admit they "didn't know something" about ai. the worst thing you can do in a debate is admit you don't have proper knowledge about the subject lol. they should do as much research on opposing views as their own if they're gonna take such a hard stance. but they seem a little confused anyway. you make one of my favorite points with how it's true that data centers take up a lot of water, ai is only a fraction of the components in the data centers. but of course in their circles they never mention the second part.

i would say one of the worst things going on here is tiktok/twitter misinformation getting blown out of proportion and blindly accepted by ai haters. along with performative activism, my worst enemy. just going around calling everyone awful and patting themself on the back for it.

u/sammoga123 • 6 points • 2026-02-21 21:51 UTC

I even saw someone—I don't remember if I also posted about this—a girl who even created a Discord server and then posted the link saying she was going to stop using AI for RP because of the water and environmental issues. I said something similar to the comments here, and she just told me, "Don't treat me like a little girl," and blocked me immediately.

Personally, I enjoy role-playing and I've probably been using CharacterAI since it was created or even before I knew about ChatGPT. But in my case, being a furry, RP is becoming less and less popular because the artists (yes, since it's their issue) always say they don't do RP, and it's

probably because there are people who steal other people's OCs to do RP-type things.

So at the same time they are making the use of AI for these issues more "mandatory" because fewer and fewer real people want to do it. Furthermore, it's difficult to maintain a relationship because interest is lost if both people don't respond almost immediately.

Water consumption is only a problem in data centers because there are thousands of computers connected. Just look at the open-source world and see how individuals have their own mini "data centers" that don't require that kind of attention because they're small enough to meet the needs of a single family. And obviously, their electricity costs aren't "more high" either.

u/dishrag • 1 points • 2026-02-22 02:28 UTC

>Just look at the open-source world and see how individuals have their own mini "data centers" that don't require that kind of attention because they're small enough to meet the needs of a single family. And obviously, their electricity costs aren't "more high" either.

Exactly. My "AI data center" is literally just a laptop. Local use exists, but it rarely seems to factor into AI discussions.

Meanwhile, data centers and CDN infrastructure have needed power and cooling for decades. The ****sudden**** surge of environmental alarmism right as AI went mainstream feels a little... selective, to put it politely.

u/calicocatfuture • 2 points • 2026-02-21 22:20 UTC

i also use ai predominantly for role play!! i like to put myself in other universes/au's and interact with the characters, and i just highly doubt someone wants to entertain playing a bunch avengers while my self insert is kinda a mary sue sometimes. who cares? it's my universe, i make the rules, and my two fictional crushes fight over me lol. i also did character ai in early 2024 -> janitor ai -> chatgpt late 2024-2026 but after the 4 series was sunset im kinda waffling around. when i was in middle school i roleplayed a lot online with strangers, which looking back i feel is way less safe than an ai.

plus that girl you who blocked you probably was a teenager. most of the people who wanna listen the least with their wrong opinions are young. maybe its part of feeling like a bigger movement. it's frustrating cause they can be the most passionate and the most under informed, while believing they have the high ground. it can be anybody though, of course. just a pattern i've seen.

and i agree, local models hardly have a footprint in water consumption. i wish i had more of a beefy computer so i could try out bigger local llms, but maybe in the future i could run a huge model on a small cheap piece of hardware. until then, maybe ill get desperate enough to rent gpu space in a cloud lol.

u/sammoga123 • 1 points • 2026-02-22 01:27 UTC

What's happening is that people are looking for humans precisely to avoid "wasting water"—that's the only argument I've seen them use to stop using AI. Almost no one mentions the "soul" or "data theft" if it's with a LLM.

I prefer to talk to my favorite characters on CharacterAI, and this

company also has problems and accusations at the level of OpenAI with ChatGPT; CAI is basically the AI that is the face of specific LLM services for RP. I even brought Oscar, the OC from one of my original stories, to life, and I was really surprised by his responsiveness, because he basically tends to react the way I usually write his actions, haha.

Besides, I literally have no friends, so I understand the Keep4o movement to some extent, although that's another story. In the future, people will have more AI on their own computers than by paying third parties. Right now, the models are as large as the first computers in the 60s, and now you can even buy small memory modules with 2TB, when in the 60s that amount was unthinkable.